

Lesson 2: “My Soul Doth Magnify the Lord” (See L2 [Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help us develop greater faith in Jesus Christ through a study of the lives of Elisabeth, Zacharias, John the Baptist, Mary, and Joseph.

1. John the Baptist is born to Elisabeth and Zacharias.

†1. Introduction to Luke †2. Prologue to the Gospel of Luke

- Read [Luke 1:5-25, 57-80](#). “7-13 And they had no child ... and they both were now well stricken in years.”

How can we remain faithful and avoid discouragement when our prayers are not immediately answered?

- Luke 1:14-17. Gabriel (Noah) prophesied about John’s mission. (See [NTSM, Introduction and Timeline for Luke 1-3](#))

What might these prophecies mean? How did John fulfill them?

- Luke 1:18-25. Zacharias said, “Whereby shall I know this? For I am an old man, and my wife well stricken in years.”

- Luke 1:59-65. Zacharias “wrote, saying, His name is called John. And they marveled all.”

- Luke 1:66-79. Zacharias prophesied, “76 And thou, child, shalt be called the prophet of the highest: for thou shalt go before the face of the lord to prepare his ways; 77 To give knowledge of salvation unto his people by the remission of their sins”.

- John 1:6-9. “There was a man sent from God, whose name was John. The same came for a witness to bear witness of the Light, that all men through him might believe...”

“Like John the Baptist, we should focus our service on helping others come to Christ.” (*Lesson Manual*)

- Luke 1:80. “And the child grew, and waxed strong in spirit, and was in the deserts ...”

³Wax (intransitive verb) means “to increase in size, numbers, strength, prosperity, or intensity ... to grow toward full development”. (merriam-webster.com)

Why do you think John needed to wax strong in spirit to be able to fulfill his mission?

What can we do to wax strong in spirit?

2. Mary and Joseph learn that Mary will be the mother of the Son of God.

- Read [Luke 1:26-56](#) and [Matthew 1:18-25](#).

- Luke 1:26-33. “And in the sixth month the angel Gabriel was sent from God ... To a virgin ... Mary.”

†3. Elder Merrill J. Bateman †4. Elder Bruce R. McConkie

- Luke 1:26-28, 45-49. “And the angel said unto her, Fear not, Mary: for thou hast found favour with God.”

What can we learn about Mary from her conversations with the angel and with Elisabeth?

- a. Mary had found favor with God (Luke 1:28, 20). What does it mean to find favor with God?

To what other sources do some look for favor? How might that hinder favor with God?

- b. Mary was worthy to have the Lord with her (Luke 1:28). What can we do to be worthy of this blessing?

- c. Mary was humble and submissive to the will of the Lord (Luke 1:38, 48).

Why is it important to submit to the Lord’s will? How can we become more humble and submissive?

- d. Mary rejoiced in the Savior (Luke 1:47). How can we rejoice in the Savior?

- Luke 1:41-55, 67-79. The praise of Elisabeth and Zacharias. †5. “My Soul Doth Magnify the Lord”

- Luke 1:39-44. Elisabeth (filled with the Holy Ghost) said, “the mother of my Lord should come to me?”

How has the Holy Ghost helped you gain a testimony of Jesus Christ, and invite others to do the same?

- Matthew 1:18-19. “Then Joseph her husband, being a just man ... was minded to put her away privily.”

“According to the law, Joseph could have accused Mary of violating the marriage covenant and brought her to a public trial. Such a trial could have resulted in a death sentence.” (*Lesson Manual*)

- Matthew 1:20-23. The Lord helped Joseph accept Mary’s condition and prepare for his own responsibilities.

- Matthew 1:24-25. “Then Joseph ... did as the angel of the Lord had bidden him, and took unto him his wife ...”

Next Week: L3 “Unto You Is Born ... a Saviour”; See L3: [Class Member Study Guide](#).

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [New Testament Student Manual: Religion 211-212](#).) † •

†1. Introduction to Luke: “Luke is the longest of the four Gospels and the longest book in the New Testament. Luke’s Gospel contains the most unique material of the three synoptic Gospels. Some of the most well-known stories of Christendom are unique to the Gospel of Luke: the traditional Christmas narrative (see Luke 2:1–20); the story of Jesus as a 12-year-old boy in the temple (see Luke 2:41–52); beloved parables such as the good Samaritan (see Luke 10:30–37) and the prodigal son (see Luke 15:11–32); the story of the ten lepers (see Luke 17:11–19); and the account of the resurrected Lord walking beside His disciples on the road to Emmaus (see Luke 24:13–32). Other unique features are Luke’s inclusion of teachings of John the Baptist not found in the other Gospels (see Luke 3:10–14); his emphasis on the prayerfulness of Jesus Christ (see Luke 3:21; 5:16; 9:18, 28–29; 11:1); and his inclusion of the calling, training, and missionary labors of the Seventy (see Luke 10:1–22). Moreover, Luke is the only Gospel writer to record that the Savior shed His blood in Gethsemane (see Luke 22:44).

“In recounting the early spread of Christianity, Luke’s Gospel demonstrates the Lord’s interest in all people—Jews, Samaritans, and Gentiles. It emphasizes the Savior’s regard for women, His empathy for the downtrodden, and His concern for those considered to be outcasts and sinners (see Luke 19:10). Because Luke’s Gospel begins and concludes at the temple, it also signals the temple’s importance as a principal location of God’s dealings with mankind (see Luke 1:9; 24:53).” (*New Testament Student Manual*, [What are some distinctive features of Luke?](#))

†2. Prologue to the Gospel of Luke: “The Gospel of Luke begins with a prologue, which is a formal introduction. The use of this literary style was customary in classical Greek literature and served to establish the purpose and importance of the work as well as the credentials of the author. Luke’s purpose was to help Theophilus “know the certainty of those things” (Luke 1:4) he had previously learned about Jesus Christ. Luke’s assertion that he “had perfect understanding of all things from the very first” (Luke 1:3) does not mean that he was an eyewitness of the Savior, but it reflects his diligence in incorporating the testimonies of eyewitnesses into his work.” (*New Testament Student Manual*, [Commentary for Luke 1-3, Luke 1:1-4.](#))

†3. Elder Merrill J. Bateman: “One might ask, ‘Why were angels so prominent at the Savior’s birth? And why were they such an important part of His life and ministry?’ The answers are twofold. The first pertains to the nature and mission of the personage whom they were heralding—a divine Being, the Son of God, the Only Begotten in the flesh who came to earth to save all of God’s children. The second concerns the ushering in of a new dispensation, a period of time when the gospel

would be restored in its fulness. The ministry of angels is to assist in the ushering in of dispensations (see Moroni 7:29–31). ...

“The last prophet of the Old Testament was Malachi, who lived 400 years before the birth of Christ. At that time Israel in large part had turned away from the covenants made with Jehovah. Consequently, they were in apostasy. Although the Aaronic Priesthood was on earth when Jesus was born, the Melchizedek Priesthood had been taken from the earth. Therefore, there was a need for the priesthood and the gospel to be restored in their fulness. ...

“At the beginning of a new dispensation following a period of apostasy, there is no one with priesthood authority to administer the covenants in their fulness. Consequently, the Lord sends messengers from the other side of the veil to return priesthood keys and the gospel plan to the earth.

“It is not surprising then that an angel visited Zacharias and instructed him with regard to the mission of his son” (“[A Season for Angels](#),” *Ensign*, Dec. 2007, 10, 14).

†4. Elder Bruce R. McConkie: “It was because of this ... intermixture of the divine and the mortal in one person, that our Lord was able to work out the infinite and eternal atonement. Because God was his Father and Mary was his mother, he had power to live or to die, as he chose, and having laid down his life, he had power to take it again, and then, in a way incomprehensible to us, to pass on the effects of that resurrection to all men so that all shall rise from the tomb” (*The Promised Messiah* [1978], 470-71).

†5. “My Soul Doth Magnify the Lord”: These verses “are traditionally known as the Song of Mary, or the Magnificat (which in Latin means ‘magnifies’). Similar hymns of praise were spoken by both Elisabeth and Zacharias... Elisabeth recognized Mary’s remarkable mission and, filled with the Holy Ghost spoke words of praise and testimony, as recorded in Luke 1:41-45... Zacharias’s hymn of praise is known as the Benedictus (which in Latin means ‘blessed’). (*New Testament Student Manual*, [Luke 1:41-55, 67-80. “My Soul Doth Magnify the Lord”](#))

Recommended Reading:

1. Elder Merrill J. Bateman, “[A Season for Angels](#),” *Ensign*, December 2007.
2. *New Testament Student Manual*, [Chapter 15: Luke 1-3.](#)

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